

1787 · 1788 · 1868 • UNITED STATES GOVERNMENT & CIVICS (GC) • COURSE
STANDARD EDITION

GOVERNMENT HACK™

TROOPTOTEACHER TECHNOLOGIES

UNIT 4

The Executive Branch

COURSE STANDARD EDITION

GC.16–GC.18 • Tennessee U.S. Government & Civics Standards • Grades 9–12

★ TENNESSEE CONNECTION

Tennessee has sent three of its own to the presidency: Andrew Jackson, James K. Polk, and Andrew Johnson all built their careers in Tennessee before reaching the White House. Andrew Johnson's presidency ended in the first impeachment trial of a President — a direct test of the checks on executive power studied in this unit (GC.16).

One common workbook designed for learner variability. Every student works toward the same Tennessee standards; supports vary the means, not the goal or the ceiling.

Release-Ready · Pilot Edition

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Government Hack™ — Unit 4: The Executive Branch, Course Standard Edition.

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Source integrity. Every primary source in this unit is public-domain and cited to its holding repository (National Archives, Library of Congress). See the Source Library.

Reading provenance (district-clear). Close-Read passages are labeled “Government Hack-authored instructional synthesis” — they build on the standard record and are not presented as primary sources.

Framework stack. This workbook anchors to Tennessee U.S. Government & Civics standards GC.16–GC.18 and the Social Studies Practices (SSP.01–SSP.06), and is designed on CAST UDL 3.0 and an MTSS support model.

Pacing. Each standard is built for **one 45-minute class period**. Each activity shows a  ~ **minutes** estimate at its heading. There is more here than one period holds — your teacher chooses which activities you do in class; the rest may become warm-ups, stations, or homework.

Table of Contents

Tennessee Standards & SSP Crosswalk

Each standard below is taught to the full Course Standard expectation; the Social Studies Practices are embedded in every activity cycle.

Standard	Focus	Student Deck slides
GC.16	Article II & the Presidency	2-8
GC.17	Departments of the Executive Branch	2-8
GC.18	The Electoral College	2-8

Social Studies Practices (SSP.01-SSP.06)

SSP.01 Gather/evaluate sources · SSP.02 Critically examine a primary source · SSP.03 Synthesize evidence · SSP.04 Construct/communicate argument · SSP.05 Develop historical awareness · SSP.06 Chronological/spatial reasoning. Each Close Read, Primary Source/Data, and CER activity names the practices it builds.

Accessibility, UDL & Accommodations Matrix

One firm learning goal per standard; flexible, universal means. Supports are available by design and never lower the goal. They work alongside — never in place of — required IEP or 504 accommodations.

Universal support	What it is	Where it appears
CORE PATH	Essential instruction every student completes	Every activity
LANGUAGE SUPPORT	Vocabulary, pronunciation, Spanish cognates	Word Bank, Guided/Light Backs
RESPONSE CHOICE	Write, say/record, or diagram	Every activity
SUPPORT OPTION	Optional scaffold that keeps the goal	Guided Support Back, Primary Source
PROGRESS CHECK	Quick DOK-2/3 check to guide reteach/extend	Cornell Notes, Practice Quiz
EXTENSION	Deeper challenge once the goal is met	Extension Bank, CER

How CAST UDL 3.0 is visible in this workbook

Multiple means of Engagement (response choice, relevance via Tennessee Connection), Representation (Word Bank, pronunciation, Spanish, Close-Read supports), and Action & Expression (write/say/diagram, Frayer, CER). No fixed-track labels appear.

My Support Plan (optional — you choose)

Supports are available by design. Check the ones you might try; you can change your mind any time.

Support I might use	When it would help me
Word Bank + Spanish column	
Guided or Light Support Back	
Response choice (say/record or diagram)	
Sentence frames / Rehearsal Lab	

How to Use This Workbook

Each standard runs the same seven-activity cycle: (1) Vocabulary Word Bank, (2) Vocabulary Studio, (3) Direct-Teaching Cornell Notes with optional Guided and Light Support Backs, (4) Close Read, (5) Primary Source / Data Analysis, (6) Core Application Practice Quiz, (7) Constructed Response (CER). Work the CORE PATH; reach for SUPPORT OPTIONS as needed.

Label legend — these appear throughout every standard cycle

Label	Meaning
CORE PATH	The essential instruction every student completes.
SUPPORT OPTION	An optional scaffold that keeps the goal, not lowers it.
LANGUAGE SUPPORT	Vocabulary, pronunciation, and Spanish cognates for access.
RESPONSE CHOICE	Show learning by writing, saying/recording, or diagramming.
PROGRESS CHECK	A quick DOK-2/3 check that guides reteach or extend.
EXTENSION	A deeper challenge once the goal is met.

Before You Begin — Set a S.M.A.R.T. Goal

Strong learners set goals — but a goal only helps if it is built well. First learn how, then write yours.

WHAT MAKES A GOAL STRONG? Build it S.M.A.R.T.

S — Specific: say exactly what you will be able to do (“explain how a bill becomes law,” not “do well”).

M — Measurable: how will you PROVE it? — a score, a diagram, or teaching a partner.

A — Achievable: a real stretch you can reach with effort — not too easy, not impossible.

R — Relevant: it connects to this unit’s big question.

T — Time-bound: name WHEN — “by the end of this unit.”

SEE THE DIFFERENCE

Weak: “I want to do good in government.” (vague — nothing to measure)

S.M.A.R.T.: “By the end of this unit I can explain how the three branches check each other, and prove it by teaching a partner and scoring 80%+ on the check.”

This unit’s big question: How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?

BUILD YOURS — write each piece on the lines, then combine them at the bottom

Fill in each part of your goal. Use the lines.

Part of my goal	Write your piece on the lines
S — Specific: what exactly will I be able to do?	_____ _____
M — Measurable: how will I prove it? (a score, a diagram, teaching a partner)	_____ _____
A — Achievable: what effort will it take to reach it?	_____ _____
R — Relevant: how does it connect to the big question above?	_____ _____
T — Time-bound: by when?	_____ _____

PUT IT TOGETHER — my S.M.A.R.T. goal in one or two sentences:

Standard GC.16 — Article II & the Presidency

TN Academic Standard GC.16: Analyze Article II of the U.S. Constitution as it relates to the executive branch, including: appointments; Commander-in-chief of the military; eligibility for office; executive orders; length of term (22nd Amendment); oath of office; powers of the president; succession (25th Amendment); treaties. (H)

LEARNING TARGETS — I can...

- I can analyze Article II — the qualifications, powers, roles, term, and succession of the President..

Lenses for this standard: History (H)

CORE PATH — the same for every student

Every student works this standard at the same rigor: analyze the sources and vocabulary, then show what you learned on the Practice Quiz and the CER. Check yourself against the learning targets on the Cornell Notes page. Supports for each step are on the back of this page.

SET YOUR GOAL (self-direction)

My goal for this standard — what will I be able to do, and how will I show it? (Need help? See the back of this page.)

HOOK — think before you dig in

One person commands the world's most powerful military — yet cannot make a treaty or hire a cabinet officer alone. Who holds the leash?

ACTIVATE — what do you already know or wonder?

Jot what you already know or want to find out about this standard. You'll come back to it.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS — before you dig in (you'll revisit this at the end)

In your own words: what do you think this standard is about, and why might it matter to you or your community? Write 2–3 sentences.

Getting Started — supports for this page — GC.16

WHAT “CORE PATH” MEANS

Everyone learns the same standard at the same level. “Support options” are just extra ways in — sentence starters, an example, a partner, or recording your answer. They help you reach the bar; they never lower it.

SET YOUR GOAL — how to write a strong one

Example goal: “By the end of this standard I can explain ___ and prove it by scoring 80%+ on the quiz.”

How to build it: name what you’ll DO, then how you’ll PROVE it, then WHEN.

Sentence starters: “I want to be able to...” “I’ll show it by...” “By the end of this standard...”

HOOK — sentence starters

“I think the big question is...” “This connects to...” “I wonder why...” “At first I believe...”

ACTIVATE — what it means & how to answer

What it means: “Activate” = wake up what you ALREADY know before you learn more.

Sentence starters: “I already know...” “This reminds me of...” “I want to find out...”

FIRST IMPRESSIONS — what to write

Just your honest first take — there is no wrong answer. Say what you THINK the standard is about and why it might matter to you, your family, or your community. You’ll come back and improve it at the end.

KEY WORDS TO WATCH FOR

Commander-in-Chief · Executive Order · Succession

NOW TRY IT — draft your goal using a starter above

Write a first draft here, then copy your best version onto the front. Aim for: what you’ll DO + how you’ll PROVE it + WHEN.

Activity 1 — Vocabulary (Part A: Reference / Word Bank) — GC.16 ~10 min

Use this word bank throughout the standard. The Spanish column supports access, not translation of assessment.

Term	Student-friendly meaning	Spanish
Commander-in-Chief	The President's role as civilian head of the U.S. armed forces, ensuring the military answers to elected leadership.	comandante en jefe
Executive Order	A directive from the President that manages the operations of the federal government and has the force of law, though it cannot override the Constitution or statute.	orden ejecutiva
Succession	The order set by the Constitution (25th Amendment) for who becomes President if the office is vacated — starting with the Vice President.	sucesión presidencial

LANGUAGE SUPPORT

Pronunciations: Commander-in-Chief (kuh-MAN-der in cheef); Executive Order (eg-ZEK-yuh-tiv OR-der); Succession (suk-SESH-un).

VOCABULARY SELF-CHECK · Knowledge Rating

Rate each term NOW in pencil, then again at the END — growth is the goal; no penalty for “never seen it.”

Term	1 · never seen it	2 · heard it	3 · can use it	4 · can teach it
Commander-in-Chief	_____	_____	_____	_____
Executive Order	_____	_____	_____	_____
Succession	_____	_____	_____	_____

MAKE IT YOURS (RESPONSE CHOICE): choose ONE term above and show you own it — write a sentence, sketch it, or give a real-world example.

QUICK WRITE

Which of these terms do you think will matter MOST for this standard, and why? You'll revisit this at the end.

Activity 2 — Vocabulary Studio (Frayer-inspired) — GC.16

~7 min

RESPONSE CHOICE — three ways to complete each studio**WRITE:** fill in the four boxes below in your own words.**SAY IT:** explain the term aloud to a partner or your teacher, or record a short voice note — say the term, its meaning, and one example.**DIAGRAM:** sketch or map the term in the Sketch Studio on the back of this page.**PRIORITY TERM 1 Commander-in-Chief** · ES: comandante en jefe**Word-bank meaning to build on:** The President's role as civilian head of the U.S. armed forces, ensuring the military answers to elected leadership.

Definition (in your own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

Use it to explain

Write one sentence that uses “Commander-in-Chief” to explain this standard.

PRIORITY TERM 2 Executive Order · ES: orden ejecutiva**Word-bank meaning to build on:** A directive from the President that manages the operations of the federal government and has the force of law, though it cannot override the Constitution or statute.

Definition (in your own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

Use it to explain

Write one sentence that uses “Executive Order” to explain this standard.

CONNECT THE TERMS (UDL · build understanding)

How do these priority terms fit together? Write how one leads to or affects another on the lines — or map it in the Sketch Studio on the back.

Activity 2 — Sketch Studio (draw it or say it) — GC.16

SAY IT — pick one way to explain your terms aloud

Explain each priority term to a shoulder partner, then have them explain one back to you.

Or explain a term to your teacher during check-in.

Or record a 20–30 second voice note: say the term, what it means, and one real example.

Or stand and share one term with the class.

DIAGRAM: Commander-in-Chief

Draw, map, or symbolize this term — a picture, an icon, a quick web, or an example scene. Label your drawing.

DIAGRAM: Executive Order

Draw, map, or symbolize this term — a picture, an icon, a quick web, or an example scene. Label your drawing.

CONNECT THE TERMS — concept map

Put both terms in the box and draw arrows to show how one leads to, needs, or affects the other. Write a few words on each arrow.

Activity 3 — Direct Teaching Cornell Notes — GC.16 ~20 min

GC.16 — Article II & the Presidency • Lean Student Deck slides 2–8 • direct-teaching slides 4–6

Your learning targets are on this standard's opening page — take notes that help you meet them.

Guiding cues	My notes — write your notes here
Key idea of this standard?	
One source that supports it?	
One check on executive power?	
Key terms →	

DOODLE ZONE — draw your thinking (UDL · another way in)

Need another way in? Sketch the key idea, a quick timeline, or how the pieces connect. Words optional.

Cornell Notes — keep going, then process & check — GC.16

UDL · CHOOSE HOW YOU CAPTURE IDEAS (same target for everyone)

Keep going with your notes: WRITE on the lines, DRAW or diagram in the box, or do both — your choice. You may also record your notes aloud.

DRAW / DIAGRAM — sketch the idea, a timeline, or how the pieces connect

WRITE — keep taking notes on the lines

Key terms to list

Commander-in-Chief · Executive Order · Succession

Summary — In your own words (2-3 sentences)

PROGRESS CHECK · one question

Which check on the President is built into the treaty and appointment powers of Article II?

- A. The President may act only during wartime
- B. The Supreme Court must approve every treaty
- C. The Senate must give its 'Advice and Consent'
- D. The House must sign every appointment

Commit before you move on — mark it, say it, or explain it aloud.

CHECK YOURSELF — how am I doing?

Which learning targets (on this standard's opening page) can you now meet? Tick the number; circle any you still need help with.

☐ **1**

My 12-15 word headline for this standard

Guided Support for the Cornell Notes — GC.16

These scaffolds support ONLY the Cornell notes — use them to take and process those notes. Optional and easy to set aside; not a separate assignment or a label.

Key vocabulary	What it means
Commander-in-Chief	The President's role as civilian head of the U.S. armed forces, ensuring the military answers to elected leadership.
Executive Order	A directive from the President that manages the operations of the federal government and has the force of law, though it cannot override the Constitution or statute.
Succession	The order set by the Constitution (25th Amendment) for who becomes President if the office is vacated — starting with the Vice President.

Break it into steps:

1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of article ii & the presidency was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of article ii & the presidency was Commander-in-Chief: The President's role as civilian head of the U.S. armed forces, ensuring the military answers to elected leadership.

GUIDED NOTE REHEARSAL LAB — practice ONE note, step by step

Build one good note here first, then copy it onto your Cornell page. Name the idea → give one piece of evidence → explain the link → write a short headline.

Step	Rehearse it here
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

TRANSFER CHECK — move one rehearsed idea onto the front notes

Light Support for the Cornell Notes — GC.16

A lighter scaffold for the SAME Cornell notes. Try the notes first; reach for this only if you need it.

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Commander-in-Chief	
Executive Order	
Succession	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below (or in your front notes):

- What does the President's oath promise, and why put that promise in the Constitution?
- How do the Senate's 'Advice and Consent' powers check the President?
- How do the 22nd and 25th Amendments limit or stabilize the presidency?

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?

Circle the Cornell cue from the front page you still need help with, and tell your teacher so we can go over it.

LIGHT PROCESSING LAB

Answer one guiding question from above in a full sentence, in your own words.

Activity 4 — Close Read — GC.16 ~15 min

Reading type: Government Hack-authored instructional synthesis. This is not a primary source. Builds SSP.03 (synthesize) and SSP.05 (historical awareness).

CORE PATH

Article II creates a single President — the head of the executive branch — and lists both the powers and the limits of the office. To serve, a President must be a natural-born citizen, at least 35, and a U.S. resident for 14 years, and must swear the oath to 'preserve, protect and defend the Constitution.' The powers are real: the President is Commander-in-Chief of the military (a civilian in charge of the armed forces), makes treaties and appointments — but only with the Senate's 'Advice and Consent' — and can issue executive orders to direct the government. Yet every power is checked. Terms are limited to two by the 22nd Amendment; the 25th Amendment sets the order of succession if the office is vacated; and Congress can impeach and remove a President. The office is powerful by design, and limited by design.

LANGUAGE SUPPORT

Key terms to know first: Commander-in-Chief, Executive Order. Read once for the gist, then again for evidence.

Text-dependent questions (answer in the Evidence Lab below or aloud):

1. What does the President's oath promise, and why put that promise in the Constitution?
2. How do the Senate's 'Advice and Consent' powers check the President?
3. How do the 22nd and 25th Amendments limit or stabilize the presidency?

RESPONSE CHOICE: answer any question by writing in the Evidence Lab, saying/recording it, or diagramming it.

CLOSE-READ EVIDENCE LAB

Log evidence from the passage below.

Question / claim	Exact passage evidence	What the evidence shows

In one sentence — the main idea of this reading:

Spaced Retrieval & Reflection — GC.16

SPACED RETRIEVAL — quick recall (no notes)

Pull it up cold to strengthen memory, then check your notes — retrieval is what makes learning stick.

Recall prompt

Your answer (from memory)

One key term or fact from THIS standard

One thing you learned in an EARLIER standard — how does it connect?

One question you can answer now that you could not before

CHECK YOURSELF — look back and score how it went

Got it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partly ☐ Not yet **Answer it from memory?** ☐ Yes ☐ With a hint ☐ No

How did it feel? ☐ Confident ☐ Getting there ☐ Shaky — I'll revisit

CONNECT IT — spiral back

How does this standard connect to one you studied earlier, or to something in the world today? Write 2-3 sentences.

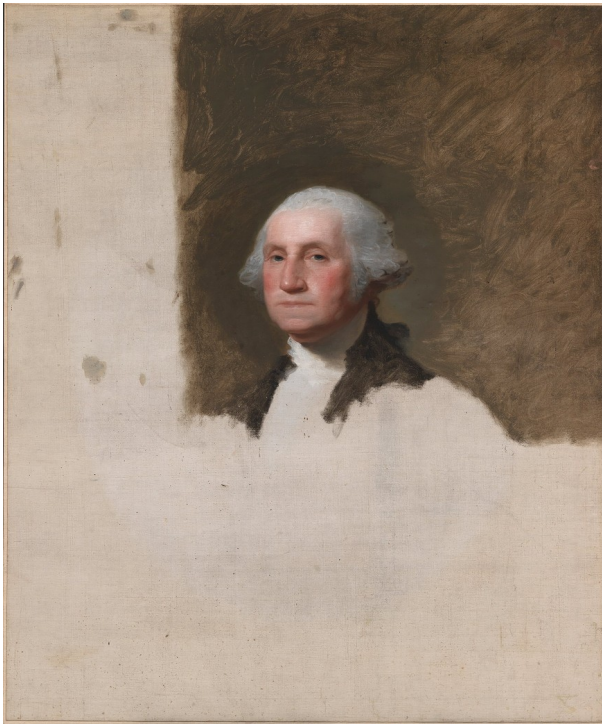
WHERE AM I? — plan your next step

Rate your understanding of this standard (1-4): ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4

One thing I will review or ask about before the quiz:

Activity 5 — Primary Source / Data Analysis — GC.16 ⌚ ~15 min

Primary source (portrait) — analyze it with HIPPO. Builds SSP.01–SSP.02.



George Washington (Athenaeum Portrait) · Gilbert Stuart · 1796

Source: Wikimedia Commons · [https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Gilbert_Stuart_-_George_Washington_\(The_Athenaeum_Portrait\)_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Gilbert_Stuart_-_George_Washington_(The_Athenaeum_Portrait)_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg) Public domain — artist d.1828; painting 1796
[https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Gilbert_Stuart_-_George_Washington_\(The_Athenaeum_Portrait\)_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Gilbert_Stuart_-_George_Washington_(The_Athenaeum_Portrait)_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg)

FIRST LOOK — before you analyze
Jot 3–4 things you notice in the source (details, words, people, dates). No wrong answers.

HIPPO — analyze the source (prompt)	Your analysis
H — Historical context: what was happening when this was created?	
I — Intended audience: who was meant to see or obey it?	
P — Purpose: why was it created?	

HIPPO — analyze the source (prompt)	Your analysis
P — Point of view: whose perspective does it reflect?	
O — Outside connection: how does it connect to this standard?	

Primary Source Analysis — go deeper — GC.16

SUPPORT OPTION (use if you need it)

Sentence frame: This source shows _____ because it _____, which reveals _____.

SOURCE SYNTHESIS — put it together (SSP.03)

In 2–3 sentences: what does this source reveal about this standard, and how do you know? Cite one specific detail from it.

THINK LIKE A HISTORIAN — corroborate or challenge (SSP.03)

Name ONE other source that could CONFIRM this one, and ONE way it could COMPLICATE or CHALLENGE it — or, whose voice is missing here?

SO WHAT? — why this source still matters today

In 1–2 sentences: why does this source still matter for understanding government today?

CONFIDENCE CHECK-IN

Rate your understanding of this standard (1–4): _____ One thing to revisit:

Activity 6 — Core Application: Practice Quiz — GC.16 ~8 min**RESPONSE CHOICE**

Commit to an answer by marking it, saying it, or explaining it aloud before checking. Answer key is in the Teacher Guide (kept separate).

[DOK 1 • item u4-gc16-dok1-1 • pre-field-test]

The 22nd Amendment limits a President to how many elected terms?

- A. One
- B. Two
- C. Three
- D. No limit

[DOK 2 • item u1-gc16-dok2-tc • pre-field-test]

Which check on the President is built into the treaty and appointment powers of Article II?

- A. The President may act only during wartime
- B. The Supreme Court must approve every treaty
- C. The Senate must give its 'Advice and Consent'
- D. The House must sign every appointment

STRETCH — think like a test-writer (open to all)

Write your OWN DOK-3 question for this standard, then a one-sentence answer key. Use the supports below — everyone can do this.

HOW TO WRITE A DOK-3 QUESTION (supports)

DOK-3 = strategic thinking: the reader must analyze, compare, evaluate, or justify using evidence — and there should be more than one defensible answer (not a fact you can just look up).

Sentence starters: “Why did _____ lead to _____?” • “Which mattered more — _____ or _____ — and why?” • “What is the BEST evidence that _____?” • “Evaluate whether _____.” • “Defend or challenge: _____.”

Frame: [Analyze / Evaluate / Justify] + [something from THIS standard] + “using evidence.”

Quick check: does my question make the reader THINK and use evidence? If yes, it's DOK-3.

NOW WRITE YOUR DOK-3 QUESTION HERE

YOUR ANSWER KEY — one clear, defensible sentence

Activity 7 — Constructed Response (CER) — GC.16 ⌚ ~15 min

BIG-QUESTION ORGANIZER (before you write) — How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?

Plan your argument here, then use it to write your claim, evidence, and reasoning below.

Plan your argument

Your quick notes (from this standard)

My claim (answer the prompt)

Evidence 1 (a source or fact)

Reasoning (why it proves the claim)

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (CER) — builds SSP.04 Argumentation

Claim + Evidence + Reasoning: Is the President's power well balanced by the checks in Article II, or does one branch hold too much? Defend your claim with evidence.

Part

Write here

Claim

Evidence (two specifics)

Reasoning

Constructed Response — self-grade & supports — GC.16

SELF-GRADE — score your own CER against the rubric below

Reread your response, then circle the level that best fits each part. Being honest here is how you level up.

Level	Claim	Evidence	Reasoning
4 — Strong	Precise, defensible	2+ accurate, specific	Explains HOW evidence proves the claim
3 — Proficient	Clear	2 accurate	Explains the link
2 — Developing	General	1 accurate	Partial link
1 — Beginning	Unclear / missing	Missing / inaccurate	No reasoning

MY SCORE

Claim: ____ / 4 Evidence: ____ / 4 Reasoning: ____ / 4 TOTAL: ____ / 12

SUPPORTS — sentence frames (use if you need them)

Claim: “_____ because _____.”

Evidence: “One example is _____ (from _____). Another is _____.”

Reasoning: “This proves my claim because _____, which shows _____.”

REVISE — make your lowest-scoring part stronger

Pick the part you scored lowest and rewrite it here — better:

Standard GC.17 — Departments of the Executive Branch

TN Academic Standard GC.17: Identify major departments of the executive branch, including: Defense; Education; Justice; State; Treasury. (—)

LEARNING TARGETS — I can...

- I can identify the major executive departments and describe what each one does to carry out the law..

Lenses for this standard: Civic Structure

CORE PATH — the same for every student

Every student works this standard at the same rigor: analyze the sources and vocabulary, then show what you learned on the Practice Quiz and the CER. Check yourself against the learning targets on the Cornell Notes page. Supports for each step are on the back of this page.

SET YOUR GOAL (self-direction)

My goal for this standard — what will I be able to do, and how will I show it? (Need help? See the back of this page.)

HOOK — think before you dig in

An outbreak, a counterfeit bill, a border dispute, a school-funding fight — four problems, four different departments. Do you know which handles which?

ACTIVATE — what do you already know or wonder?

Jot what you already know or want to find out about this standard. You'll come back to it.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS — before you dig in (you'll revisit this at the end)

In your own words: what do you think this standard is about, and why might it matter to you or your community? Write 2-3 sentences.

Getting Started — supports for this page — GC.17

WHAT “CORE PATH” MEANS

Everyone learns the same standard at the same level. “Support options” are just extra ways in — sentence starters, an example, a partner, or recording your answer. They help you reach the bar; they never lower it.

SET YOUR GOAL — how to write a strong one

Example goal: “By the end of this standard I can explain ___ and prove it by scoring 80%+ on the quiz.”

How to build it: name what you’ll DO, then how you’ll PROVE it, then WHEN.

Sentence starters: “I want to be able to...” “I’ll show it by...” “By the end of this standard...”

HOOK — sentence starters

“I think the big question is...” “This connects to...” “I wonder why...” “At first I believe...”

ACTIVATE — what it means & how to answer

What it means: “Activate” = wake up what you ALREADY know before you learn more.

Sentence starters: “I already know...” “This reminds me of...” “I want to find out...”

FIRST IMPRESSIONS — what to write

Just your honest first take — there is no wrong answer. Say what you THINK the standard is about and why it might matter to you, your family, or your community. You’ll come back and improve it at the end.

KEY WORDS TO WATCH FOR

Bureaucracy · Cabinet · Iron Triangle

NOW TRY IT — draft your goal using a starter above

Write a first draft here, then copy your best version onto the front. Aim for: what you’ll DO + how you’ll PROVE it + WHEN.

Activity 1 — Vocabulary (Part A: Reference / Word Bank) — GC.17 ~10 min

Use this word bank throughout the standard. The Spanish column supports access, not translation of assessment.

Term	Student-friendly meaning	Spanish
Bureaucracy	The departments, agencies, and employees of the executive branch that carry out and administer federal laws and programs day to day.	burocracia
Cabinet	The group of the heads (secretaries) of the executive departments who advise the President.	gabinete
Iron Triangle	The close relationship among a federal agency, a congressional committee, and interest groups that shapes policy in a specific area.	triángulo de hierro

LANGUAGE SUPPORT

Pronunciations: Bureaucracy (byoo-ROK-ruh-see); Cabinet (KAB-ih-net); Iron Triangle (EYE-urn TRY-ang-gul).

VOCABULARY SELF-CHECK · Knowledge Rating

Rate each term NOW in pencil, then again at the END — growth is the goal; no penalty for “never seen it.”

Term	1 · never seen it	2 · heard it	3 · can use it	4 · can teach it
Bureaucracy	_____	_____	_____	_____
Cabinet	_____	_____	_____	_____
Iron Triangle	_____	_____	_____	_____

MAKE IT YOURS (RESPONSE CHOICE): choose ONE term above and show you own it — write a sentence, sketch it, or give a real-world example.

QUICK WRITE

Which of these terms do you think will matter MOST for this standard, and why? You'll revisit this at the end.

Activity 2 — Vocabulary Studio (Frayer-inspired) — GC.17

~7 min

RESPONSE CHOICE — three ways to complete each studio**WRITE:** fill in the four boxes below in your own words.**SAY IT:** explain the term aloud to a partner or your teacher, or record a short voice note — say the term, its meaning, and one example.**DIAGRAM:** sketch or map the term in the Sketch Studio on the back of this page.**PRIORITY TERM 1 Bureaucracy** · ES: burocracia**Word-bank meaning to build on:** The departments, agencies, and employees of the executive branch that carry out and administer federal laws and programs day to day.

Definition (in your own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

Use it to explain

Write one sentence that uses “Bureaucracy” to explain this standard.

PRIORITY TERM 2 Cabinet · ES: gabinete**Word-bank meaning to build on:** The group of the heads (secretaries) of the executive departments who advise the President.

Definition (in your own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

Use it to explain

Write one sentence that uses “Cabinet” to explain this standard.

CONNECT THE TERMS (UDL · build understanding)

How do these priority terms fit together? Write how one leads to or affects another on the lines — or map it in the Sketch Studio on the back.

Activity 2 — Sketch Studio (draw it or say it) — GC.17

SAY IT — pick one way to explain your terms aloud

Explain each priority term to a shoulder partner, then have them explain one back to you.

Or explain a term to your teacher during check-in.

Or record a 20–30 second voice note: say the term, what it means, and one real example.

Or stand and share one term with the class.

DIAGRAM: Bureaucracy

Draw, map, or symbolize this term — a picture, an icon, a quick web, or an example scene. Label your drawing.

DIAGRAM: Cabinet

Draw, map, or symbolize this term — a picture, an icon, a quick web, or an example scene. Label your drawing.

CONNECT THE TERMS — concept map

Put both terms in the box and draw arrows to show how one leads to, needs, or affects the other. Write a few words on each arrow.

Activity 3 — Direct Teaching Cornell Notes — GC.17 ~20 min

GC.17 — Departments of the Executive Branch • Lean Student Deck slides 2–8 • direct-teaching slides 4–6

Your learning targets are on this standard's opening page — take notes that help you meet them.

Guiding cues	My notes — write your notes here
Key idea of this standard?	
One source that supports it?	
One check on executive power?	
Key terms →	

DOODLE ZONE — draw your thinking (UDL · another way in)

Need another way in? Sketch the key idea, a quick timeline, or how the pieces connect. Words optional.

Cornell Notes — keep going, then process & check — GC.17

UDL · CHOOSE HOW YOU CAPTURE IDEAS (same target for everyone)

Keep going with your notes: WRITE on the lines, DRAW or diagram in the box, or do both — your choice. You may also record your notes aloud.

DRAW / DIAGRAM — sketch the idea, a timeline, or how the pieces connect

WRITE — keep taking notes on the lines

Key terms to list

Bureaucracy · Cabinet · Iron Triangle

Summary — In your own words (2-3 sentences)

PROGRESS CHECK · one question

Which executive department is chiefly responsible for foreign policy and relations with other countries?

- A. The Department of the Treasury
- B. The Department of State
- C. The Department of Defense
- D. The Department of Education

Commit before you move on — mark it, say it, or explain it aloud.

CHECK YOURSELF — how am I doing?

Which learning targets (on this standard's opening page) can you now meet? Tick the number; circle any you still need help with.

☐ **1**

My 12-15 word headline for this standard

Guided Support for the Cornell Notes — GC.17

These scaffolds support ONLY the Cornell notes — use them to take and process those notes. Optional and easy to set aside; not a separate assignment or a label.

Key vocabulary	What it means
Bureaucracy	The departments, agencies, and employees of the executive branch that carry out and administer federal laws and programs day to day.
Cabinet	The group of the heads (secretaries) of the executive departments who advise the President.
Iron Triangle	The close relationship among a federal agency, a congressional committee, and interest groups that shapes policy in a specific area.

Break it into steps:

1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of departments of the executive branch was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of departments of the executive branch was Bureaucracy: The departments, agencies, and employees of the executive branch that carry out and administer federal laws and programs day to day.

GUIDED NOTE REHEARSAL LAB — practice ONE note, step by step

Build one good note here first, then copy it onto your Cornell page. Name the idea → give one piece of evidence → explain the link → write a short headline.

Step	Rehearse it here
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

TRANSFER CHECK — move one rehearsed idea onto the front notes

Light Support for the Cornell Notes — GC.17

A lighter scaffold for the SAME Cornell notes. Try the notes first; reach for this only if you need it.

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Bureaucracy	
Cabinet	
Iron Triangle	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below (or in your front notes):

- What does the Take Care Clause require of the President, and why does that create a need for departments?
- Match each of the five major departments to the kind of problem it handles.
- What is an 'iron triangle,' and how might it shape policy?

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?

Circle the Cornell cue from the front page you still need help with, and tell your teacher so we can go over it.

LIGHT PROCESSING LAB

Answer one guiding question from above in a full sentence, in your own words.

Activity 4 — Close Read — GC.17 ~15 min

Reading type: Government Hack-authored instructional synthesis. This is not a primary source. Builds SSP.03 (synthesize) and SSP.05 (historical awareness).

CORE PATH

The Constitution makes the President responsible to 'take Care that the Laws be faithfully executed' — but no one person can run a country of over 330 million people. So the executive branch is organized into departments, each led by a secretary who sits in the President's Cabinet. Five of the major departments show the range of the job: State manages foreign policy and diplomacy; Treasury handles money, taxes, and the debt; Defense runs the armed forces; Justice enforces federal law and runs the courts and FBI; and Education sets federal school policy and funding. Together these departments and their agencies form the bureaucracy — the millions of federal workers who carry out the law day to day. Because agencies, congressional committees, and interest groups often work closely together on the same issues, analysts call that relationship an 'iron triangle.'

LANGUAGE SUPPORT

Key terms to know first: Bureaucracy, Cabinet. Read once for the gist, then again for evidence.

Text-dependent questions (answer in the Evidence Lab below or aloud):

1. What does the Take Care Clause require of the President, and why does that create a need for departments?
2. Match each of the five major departments to the kind of problem it handles.
3. What is an 'iron triangle,' and how might it shape policy?

RESPONSE CHOICE: answer any question by writing in the Evidence Lab, saying/recording it, or diagramming it.

CLOSE-READ EVIDENCE LAB

Log evidence from the passage below.

Question / claim	Exact passage evidence	What the evidence shows

In one sentence — the main idea of this reading:

Spaced Retrieval & Reflection — GC.17

SPACED RETRIEVAL — quick recall (no notes)

Pull it up cold to strengthen memory, then check your notes — retrieval is what makes learning stick.

Recall prompt

Your answer (from memory)

One key term or fact from THIS standard

One thing you learned in an EARLIER standard — how does it connect?

One question you can answer now that you could not before

CHECK YOURSELF — look back and score how it went

Got it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partly ☐ Not yet **Answer it from memory?** ☐ Yes ☐ With a hint ☐ No

How did it feel? ☐ Confident ☐ Getting there ☐ Shaky — I'll revisit

CONNECT IT — spiral back

How does this standard connect to one you studied earlier, or to something in the world today? Write 2-3 sentences.

WHERE AM I? — plan your next step

Rate your understanding of this standard (1-4): ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4

One thing I will review or ask about before the quiz:

Activity 5 — Primary Source / Data Analysis — GC.17 ⌚ ~15 min

Primary source (emblem) — analyze it with HIPPO. Builds SSP.01–SSP.02.



Seal of the U.S. Department of State (1900) · U.S. Dept. of State · 1900

Source: Wikimedia Commons ·
[https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Seal_of_the_United_States_Department_of_State_\(1900\).png](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Seal_of_the_United_States_Department_of_State_(1900).png) Public domain —
U.S. federal government work; pre-1929
[https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Seal_of_the_United_States_Department_of_State_\(1900\).png](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Seal_of_the_United_States_Department_of_State_(1900).png)

FIRST LOOK — before you analyze
Jot 3–4 things you notice in the source (details, words, people, dates). No wrong answers.

HIPPO — analyze the source (prompt)	Your analysis
H — Historical context: what was happening when this was created?	
I — Intended audience: who was meant to see or obey it?	
P — Purpose: why was it created?	

HIPPO — analyze the source (prompt)	Your analysis
P — Point of view: whose perspective does it reflect?	
O — Outside connection: how does it connect to this standard?	

Primary Source Analysis — go deeper — GC.17

SUPPORT OPTION (use if you need it)

Sentence frame: This source shows _____ because it _____, which reveals _____.

SOURCE SYNTHESIS — put it together (SSP.03)

In 2–3 sentences: what does this source reveal about this standard, and how do you know? Cite one specific detail from it.

THINK LIKE A HISTORIAN — corroborate or challenge (SSP.03)

Name ONE other source that could CONFIRM this one, and ONE way it could COMPLICATE or CHALLENGE it — or, whose voice is missing here?

SO WHAT? — why this source still matters today

In 1–2 sentences: why does this source still matter for understanding government today?

CONFIDENCE CHECK-IN

Rate your understanding of this standard (1–4): _____ One thing to revisit:

Activity 6 — Core Application: Practice Quiz — GC.17 ~8 min**RESPONSE CHOICE**

Commit to an answer by marking it, saying it, or explaining it aloud before checking. Answer key is in the Teacher Guide (kept separate).

[DOK 1 · item u4-gc17-dok1-1 · pre-field-test]

The heads of the executive departments who advise the President make up the:

- A. Cabinet
- B. Senate
- C. Electoral College
- D. Supreme Court

[DOK 2 · item u1-gc17-dok2-tc · pre-field-test]

Which executive department is chiefly responsible for foreign policy and relations with other countries?

- A. The Department of the Treasury
- B. The Department of State
- C. The Department of Defense
- D. The Department of Education

STRETCH — think like a test-writer (open to all)

Write your OWN DOK-3 question for this standard, then a one-sentence answer key. Use the supports below — everyone can do this.

HOW TO WRITE A DOK-3 QUESTION (supports)

DOK-3 = strategic thinking: the reader must analyze, compare, evaluate, or justify using evidence — and there should be more than one defensible answer (not a fact you can just look up).

Sentence starters: “Why did _____ lead to _____?” · “Which mattered more — _____ or _____ — and why?” · “What is the BEST evidence that _____?” · “Evaluate whether _____.” · “Defend or challenge: _____.”

Frame: [Analyze / Evaluate / Justify] + [something from THIS standard] + “using evidence.”

Quick check: does my question make the reader THINK and use evidence? If yes, it's DOK-3.

NOW WRITE YOUR DOK-3 QUESTION HERE

YOUR ANSWER KEY — one clear, defensible sentence

Activity 7 — Constructed Response (CER) — GC.17 ⌚ ~15 min

BIG-QUESTION ORGANIZER (before you write) — How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?

Plan your argument here, then use it to write your claim, evidence, and reasoning below.

Plan your argument

Your quick notes (from this standard)

My claim (answer the prompt)

Evidence 1 (a source or fact)

Reasoning (why it proves the claim)

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (CER) — builds SSP.04 Argumentation

Claim + Evidence + Reasoning: Which executive department has the greatest effect on your daily life? Defend your claim with evidence about what it does.

Part

Write here

Claim

Evidence (two specifics)

Reasoning

Constructed Response — self-grade & supports — GC.17

SELF-GRADE — score your own CER against the rubric below

Reread your response, then circle the level that best fits each part. Being honest here is how you level up.

Level	Claim	Evidence	Reasoning
4 — Strong	Precise, defensible	2+ accurate, specific	Explains HOW evidence proves the claim
3 — Proficient	Clear	2 accurate	Explains the link
2 — Developing	General	1 accurate	Partial link
1 — Beginning	Unclear / missing	Missing / inaccurate	No reasoning

MY SCORE

Claim: ____ / 4 Evidence: ____ / 4 Reasoning: ____ / 4 TOTAL: ____ / 12

SUPPORTS — sentence frames (use if you need them)

Claim: “_____ because _____.”

Evidence: “One example is _____ (from _____). Another is _____.”

Reasoning: “This proves my claim because _____, which shows _____.”

REVISE — make your lowest-scoring part stronger

Pick the part you scored lowest and rewrite it here — better:

Standard GC.18 — The Electoral College

TN Academic Standard GC.18: Explain the Electoral College system and compare and contrast arguments for and against it. (G, H)

LEARNING TARGETS — I can...

- I can explain how the Electoral College works and weigh the arguments for and against it..

Lenses for this standard: Geography (G) · History (H)

CORE PATH — the same for every student

Every student works this standard at the same rigor: analyze the sources and vocabulary, then show what you learned on the Practice Quiz and the CER. Check yourself against the learning targets on the Cornell Notes page. Supports for each step are on the back of this page.

SET YOUR GOAL (self-direction)

My goal for this standard — what will I be able to do, and how will I show it? (Need help? See the back of this page.)

HOOK — think before you dig in

You never actually vote for President — you vote for someone who does. Meet the electors, and decide if the system still makes sense.

ACTIVATE — what do you already know or wonder?

Jot what you already know or want to find out about this standard. You'll come back to it.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS — before you dig in (you'll revisit this at the end)

In your own words: what do you think this standard is about, and why might it matter to you or your community? Write 2–3 sentences.

Getting Started — supports for this page — GC.18

WHAT “CORE PATH” MEANS

Everyone learns the same standard at the same level. “Support options” are just extra ways in — sentence starters, an example, a partner, or recording your answer. They help you reach the bar; they never lower it.

SET YOUR GOAL — how to write a strong one

Example goal: “By the end of this standard I can explain ___ and prove it by scoring 80%+ on the quiz.”

How to build it: name what you’ll DO, then how you’ll PROVE it, then WHEN.

Sentence starters: “I want to be able to...” “I’ll show it by...” “By the end of this standard...”

HOOK — sentence starters

“I think the big question is...” “This connects to...” “I wonder why...” “At first I believe...”

ACTIVATE — what it means & how to answer

What it means: “Activate” = wake up what you ALREADY know before you learn more.

Sentence starters: “I already know...” “This reminds me of...” “I want to find out...”

FIRST IMPRESSIONS — what to write

Just your honest first take — there is no wrong answer. Say what you THINK the standard is about and why it might matter to you, your family, or your community. You’ll come back and improve it at the end.

KEY WORDS TO WATCH FOR

Electoral College · Elector · Winner-Take-All

NOW TRY IT — draft your goal using a starter above

Write a first draft here, then copy your best version onto the front. Aim for: what you’ll DO + how you’ll PROVE it + WHEN.

Activity 1 — Vocabulary (Part A: Reference / Word Bank) — GC.18

 ~10 min

Use this word bank throughout the standard. The Spanish column supports access, not translation of assessment.

Term	Student-friendly meaning	Spanish
Electoral College	The body of electors — one per senator and representative — that formally elects the President; a candidate needs a majority (270 of 538).	Colegio Electoral
Elector	A person chosen by each state to cast that state's official vote for President based on the state's popular vote.	elector
Winner-Take-All	The practice, used by most states, of awarding all of a state's electoral votes to whichever candidate wins that state's popular vote.	el ganador se lleva todo

LANGUAGE SUPPORT

Pronunciations: Electoral College (ee-LEK-tor-ul KOL-ij); Elector (ee-LEK-ter); Winner-Take-All (WIN-er take all).

VOCABULARY SELF-CHECK • Knowledge Rating

Rate each term NOW in pencil, then again at the END — growth is the goal; no penalty for “never seen it.”

Term	1 • never seen it	2 • heard it	3 • can use it	4 • can teach it
Electoral College	_____	_____	_____	_____
Elector	_____	_____	_____	_____
Winner-Take-All	_____	_____	_____	_____

MAKE IT YOURS (RESPONSE CHOICE): choose ONE term above and show you own it — write a sentence, sketch it, or give a real-world example.

QUICK WRITE

Which of these terms do you think will matter MOST for this standard, and why? You'll revisit this at the end.

Activity 2 — Vocabulary Studio (Frayer-inspired) — GC.18

~7 min

RESPONSE CHOICE — three ways to complete each studio**WRITE:** fill in the four boxes below in your own words.**SAY IT:** explain the term aloud to a partner or your teacher, or record a short voice note — say the term, its meaning, and one example.**DIAGRAM:** sketch or map the term in the Sketch Studio on the back of this page.**PRIORITY TERM 1 Electoral College** · ES: Colegio Electoral**Word-bank meaning to build on:** The body of electors — one per senator and representative — that formally elects the President; a candidate needs a majority (270 of 538).

Definition (in your own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

Use it to explain

Write one sentence that uses “Electoral College” to explain this standard.

PRIORITY TERM 2 Winner-Take-All · ES: el ganador se lleva todo**Word-bank meaning to build on:** The practice, used by most states, of awarding all of a state's electoral votes to whichever candidate wins that state's popular vote.

Definition (in your own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

Use it to explain

Write one sentence that uses “Winner-Take-All” to explain this standard.

CONNECT THE TERMS (UDL · build understanding)

How do these priority terms fit together? Write how one leads to or affects another on the lines — or map it in the Sketch Studio on the back.

Activity 2 — Sketch Studio (draw it or say it) — GC.18

SAY IT — pick one way to explain your terms aloud

Explain each priority term to a shoulder partner, then have them explain one back to you.

Or explain a term to your teacher during check-in.

Or record a 20–30 second voice note: say the term, what it means, and one real example.

Or stand and share one term with the class.

DIAGRAM: Electoral College

Draw, map, or symbolize this term — a picture, an icon, a quick web, or an example scene. Label your drawing.

DIAGRAM: Winner-Take-All

Draw, map, or symbolize this term — a picture, an icon, a quick web, or an example scene. Label your drawing.

CONNECT THE TERMS — concept map

Put both terms in the box and draw arrows to show how one leads to, needs, or affects the other. Write a few words on each arrow.

Activity 3 — Direct Teaching Cornell Notes — GC.18 ~20 min

GC.18 — The Electoral College • Lean Student Deck slides 2-8 • direct-teaching slides 4-6

Your learning targets are on this standard's opening page — take notes that help you meet them.

Guiding cues	My notes — write your notes here
Key idea of this standard?	
One source that supports it?	
One check on executive power?	
Key terms →	

DOODLE ZONE — draw your thinking (UDL · another way in)

Need another way in? Sketch the key idea, a quick timeline, or how the pieces connect. Words optional.

Cornell Notes — keep going, then process & check — GC.18

UDL · CHOOSE HOW YOU CAPTURE IDEAS (same target for everyone)

Keep going with your notes: WRITE on the lines, DRAW or diagram in the box, or do both — your choice. You may also record your notes aloud.

DRAW / DIAGRAM — sketch the idea, a timeline, or how the pieces connect

WRITE — keep taking notes on the lines

Key terms to list

Electoral College · Elector · Winner-Take-All

Summary — In your own words (2-3 sentences)

PROGRESS CHECK · one question

Why can a candidate win the national popular vote yet still lose the presidency?

- A. Because the Supreme Court chooses the President
- B. Because Congress ignores the popular vote entirely
- C. Because the President is chosen by the Cabinet
- D. Because most states award all their electoral votes winner-take-all, so the Electoral College total can differ from the national vote

Commit before you move on — mark it, say it, or explain it aloud.

CHECK YOURSELF — how am I doing?

Which learning targets (on this standard's opening page) can you now meet? Tick the number; circle any you still need help with.

☐ **1**

My 12-15 word headline for this standard

Guided Support for the Cornell Notes — GC.18

These scaffolds support ONLY the Cornell notes — use them to take and process those notes. Optional and easy to set aside; not a separate assignment or a label.

Key vocabulary	What it means
Electoral College	The body of electors — one per senator and representative — that formally elects the President; a candidate needs a majority (270 of 538).
Elector	A person chosen by each state to cast that state's official vote for President based on the state's popular vote.
Winner-Take-All	The practice, used by most states, of awarding all of a state's electoral votes to whichever candidate wins that state's popular vote.

Break it into steps:

1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of the electoral college was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of the electoral college was Electoral College: The body of electors — one per senator and representative — that formally elects the President; a candidate needs a majority (270 of 538).

GUIDED NOTE REHEARSAL LAB — practice ONE note, step by step

Build one good note here first, then copy it onto your Cornell page. Name the idea → give one piece of evidence → explain the link → write a short headline.

Step	Rehearse it here
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

TRANSFER CHECK — move one rehearsed idea onto the front notes

Light Support for the Cornell Notes — GC.18

A lighter scaffold for the SAME Cornell notes. Try the notes first; reach for this only if you need it.

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Electoral College	
Elector	
Winner-Take-All	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below (or in your front notes):

- How does a state decide its number of electors, according to Article II?
- What argument does Hamilton make for the Electoral College in Federalist 68?
- State one argument for and one against the Electoral College, and say which you find stronger.

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?

Circle the Cornell cue from the front page you still need help with, and tell your teacher so we can go over it.

LIGHT PROCESSING LAB

Answer one guiding question from above in a full sentence, in your own words.

Activity 4 — Close Read — GC.18 ~15 min

Reading type: Government Hack-authored instructional synthesis. This is not a primary source. Builds SSP.03 (synthesize) and SSP.05 (historical awareness).

CORE PATH

Americans do not elect the President directly. Instead, each state appoints electors — equal to its number of senators plus representatives — and those electors formally choose the President, with 270 of 538 needed to win. Alexander Hamilton defended the design in Federalist 68, arguing it let 'the sense of the people' operate while filtering the choice through informed electors. Because most states award all their electors winner-take-all, a candidate can win the national popular vote and still lose the Electoral College — which has happened and fuels an ongoing debate. Supporters say the system protects smaller states and forces national campaigns; critics say it can override the popular will and focuses attention on a few 'swing' states. If no candidate wins a majority, the House chooses the President. Whatever one concludes, the Electoral College shows the Framers' habit of balancing popular voice against structure.

LANGUAGE SUPPORT

Key terms to know first: Electoral College, Elector. Read once for the gist, then again for evidence.

Text-dependent questions (answer in the Evidence Lab below or aloud):

1. How does a state decide its number of electors, according to Article II?
2. What argument does Hamilton make for the Electoral College in Federalist 68?
3. State one argument for and one against the Electoral College, and say which you find stronger.

RESPONSE CHOICE: answer any question by writing in the Evidence Lab, saying/recording it, or diagramming it.

CLOSE-READ EVIDENCE LAB

Log evidence from the passage below.

Question / claim	Exact passage evidence	What the evidence shows

In one sentence — the main idea of this reading:

Spaced Retrieval & Reflection — GC.18

SPACED RETRIEVAL — quick recall (no notes)

Pull it up cold to strengthen memory, then check your notes — retrieval is what makes learning stick.

Recall prompt	Your answer (from memory)
One key term or fact from THIS standard	
One thing you learned in an EARLIER standard — how does it connect?	
One question you can answer now that you could not before	

CHECK YOURSELF — look back and score how it went

Got it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partly ☐ Not yet **Answer it from memory?** ☐ Yes ☐ With a hint ☐ No

How did it feel? ☐ Confident ☐ Getting there ☐ Shaky — I'll revisit

CONNECT IT — spiral back

How does this standard connect to one you studied earlier, or to something in the world today? Write 2-3 sentences.

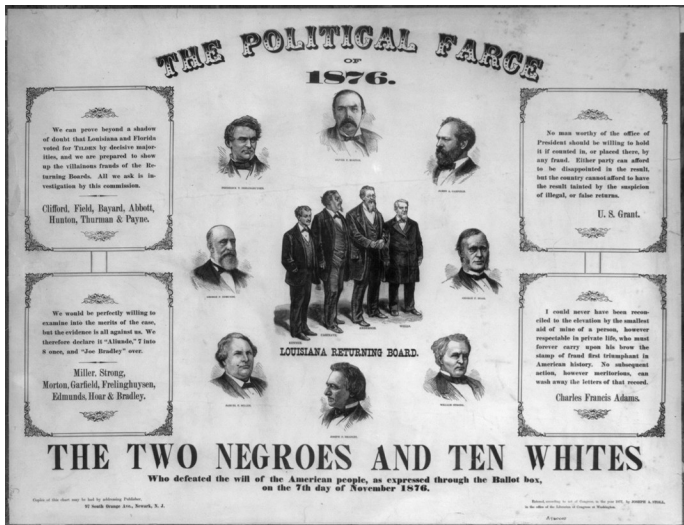
WHERE AM I? — plan your next step

Rate your understanding of this standard (1-4): ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4

One thing I will review or ask about before the quiz:

Activity 5 — Primary Source / Data Analysis — GC.18 ~15 min

Primary source (cartoon) — analyze it with HIPPO. Builds SSP.01–SSP.02.



The Political Farce of 1876 (Hayes-Tilden) • (unattributed) • 1876

Source: Library of Congress • <https://www.loc.gov/item/2006677483/> Public domain — 1876 lithograph (pre-1929) <https://www.loc.gov/item/2006677483/>

FIRST LOOK — before you analyze

Jot 3–4 things you notice in the source (details, words, people, dates). No wrong answers.

HIPPO — analyze the source (prompt)	Your analysis
H — Historical context: what was happening when this was created?	
I — Intended audience: who was meant to see or obey it?	
P — Purpose: why was it created?	
P — Point of view: whose perspective does it reflect?	

HIPPO — analyze the source (prompt)	Your analysis
O — Outside connection: how does it connect to this standard?	

Primary Source Analysis — go deeper — GC.18

SUPPORT OPTION (use if you need it)

Sentence frame: This source shows _____ because it _____, which reveals _____.

SOURCE SYNTHESIS — put it together (SSP.03)

In 2–3 sentences: what does this source reveal about this standard, and how do you know? Cite one specific detail from it.

THINK LIKE A HISTORIAN — corroborate or challenge (SSP.03)

Name ONE other source that could CONFIRM this one, and ONE way it could COMPLICATE or CHALLENGE it — or, whose voice is missing here?

SO WHAT? — why this source still matters today

In 1–2 sentences: why does this source still matter for understanding government today?

CONFIDENCE CHECK-IN

Rate your understanding of this standard (1–4): _____ One thing to revisit:

Activity 6 — Core Application: Practice Quiz — GC.18 ~8 min**RESPONSE CHOICE**

Commit to an answer by marking it, saying it, or explaining it aloud before checking. Answer key is in the Teacher Guide (kept separate).

[DOK 1 • item u4-gc18-dok1-1 • pre-field-test]

How many electoral votes are needed to win the presidency?

- A. 218
- B. 270
- C. 435
- D. 538

[DOK 3 • item u1-gc18-dok3-tc • pre-field-test]

Why can a candidate win the national popular vote yet still lose the presidency?

- A. Because the Supreme Court chooses the President
- B. Because Congress ignores the popular vote entirely
- C. Because the President is chosen by the Cabinet
- D. Because most states award all their electoral votes winner-take-all, so the Electoral College total can differ from the national vote

STRETCH — think like a test-writer (open to all)

Write your OWN DOK-3 question for this standard, then a one-sentence answer key. Use the supports below — everyone can do this.

HOW TO WRITE A DOK-3 QUESTION (supports)

DOK-3 = strategic thinking: the reader must analyze, compare, evaluate, or justify using evidence — and there should be more than one defensible answer (not a fact you can just look up).

Sentence starters: “Why did _____ lead to _____?” • “Which mattered more — _____ or _____ — and why?” • “What is the BEST evidence that _____?” • “Evaluate whether _____.” • “Defend or challenge: _____.”

Frame: [Analyze / Evaluate / Justify] + [something from THIS standard] + “using evidence.”

Quick check: does my question make the reader THINK and use evidence? If yes, it's DOK-3.

NOW WRITE YOUR DOK-3 QUESTION HERE

YOUR ANSWER KEY — one clear, defensible sentence

Activity 7 — Constructed Response (CER) — GC.18 ~15 min

BIG-QUESTION ORGANIZER (before you write) — How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?

Plan your argument here, then use it to write your claim, evidence, and reasoning below.

Plan your argument

Your quick notes (from this standard)

My claim (answer the prompt)

Evidence 1 (a source or fact)

Reasoning (why it proves the claim)

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (CER) — builds SSP.04 Argumentation

Claim + Evidence + Reasoning: Should the United States keep, reform, or replace the Electoral College? Defend your claim with an argument on each side.

Part

Write here

Claim

Evidence (two specifics)

Reasoning

Constructed Response — self-grade & supports — GC.18

SELF-GRADE — score your own CER against the rubric below

Reread your response, then circle the level that best fits each part. Being honest here is how you level up.

Level	Claim	Evidence	Reasoning
4 — Strong	Precise, defensible	2+ accurate, specific	Explains HOW evidence proves the claim
3 — Proficient	Clear	2 accurate	Explains the link
2 — Developing	General	1 accurate	Partial link
1 — Beginning	Unclear / missing	Missing / inaccurate	No reasoning

MY SCORE

Claim: ____ / 4 Evidence: ____ / 4 Reasoning: ____ / 4 TOTAL: ____ / 12

SUPPORTS — sentence frames (use if you need them)

Claim: “_____ because _____.”

Evidence: “One example is _____ (from _____). Another is _____.”

Reasoning: “This proves my claim because _____, which shows _____.”

REVISE — make your lowest-scoring part stronger

Pick the part you scored lowest and rewrite it here — better:

Your Tennessee Connection

★ TENNESSEE CONNECTION

Tennessee has sent three of its own to the presidency: Andrew Jackson, James K. Polk, and Andrew Johnson all built their careers in Tennessee before reaching the White House. Andrew Johnson's presidency ended in the first impeachment trial of a President — a direct test of the checks on executive power studied in this unit (GC.16).

Reflect (RESPONSE CHOICE): How does a Tennessee connection change the way you understand a national idea? Answer by writing, recording, or diagramming.

Tennessee Civics Investigation

Three Presidents called Tennessee home. Choose one — Jackson, Polk, or Johnson — and investigate one power of the presidency they used or tested, and record what you find with a source.

Prompt	Your findings
A Tennessee example	

Prompt	Your findings
connected to this unit	
One source I could check (library, TN Secretary of State, TSLA, a representative's office)	
How it connects to a standard in this unit	
One question I still have	

Progress Tracker & Cumulative Review

Track your Progress Check result for each standard and note one thing to revisit.

Standard	Progress Check (✓ / reteach)	One thing to revisit
GC.16		
GC.17		
GC.18		

Optional Extension Bank (higher-DOK, open to all)

Any student may choose an extension. These are EXTENSION, not a track.

GC.16: Is the President's power well balanced by the checks in Article II, or does one branch hold too much? Defend your claim with evidence.

GC.17: Which executive department has the greatest effect on your daily life? Defend your claim with evidence about what it does.

GC.18: Should the United States keep, reform, or replace the Electoral College? Defend your claim with an argument on each side.

Reusable Toolkit & Source Library

Written Response Rubric (CER)

Level	Claim	Evidence	Reasoning
4 — Strong	Precise, defensible	2+ accurate, specific	Explains how evidence proves the claim
3 — Proficient	Clear	2 accurate	Explains the link
2 — Developing	General	1 accurate	Partial link
1 — Beginning	Unclear/missing	Missing/inaccurate	No reasoning

Source Library — full citations & clickable links

GC.16 — Article II & the Presidency

U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 1 (Oath). Constitutional Convention, 1787. U.S. National Archives. Public domain. <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/constitution-transcript>

U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 2. Constitutional Convention, 1787. U.S. National Archives. Public domain. <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/constitution-transcript>

GC.17 — Departments of the Executive Branch

U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 2. Constitutional Convention, 1787. U.S. National Archives. Public domain. <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/constitution-transcript>

U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 3 (Take Care Clause). Constitutional Convention, 1787. U.S. National Archives. Public domain. <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/constitution-transcript>

GC.18 — The Electoral College

U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 1. Constitutional Convention, 1787. U.S. National Archives. Public domain. <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/constitution-transcript>

Federalist No. 68. Alexander Hamilton (Publius), 1788. The Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain. https://avalon.law.yale.edu/18th_century/fed68.asp

How Strong Should the President Be? Perspectives on Executive Power

This section weighs a central tension of the office: energy in the executive versus the danger of one person holding too much power. It is Government Hack–authored instructional synthesis grounded in this unit's sourced record — not a primary source.

Energy in the Executive

Hamilton argued a single, energetic executive is essential to act decisively in war and crisis (Federalist 68/70; connects to GC.16).

Fear of a King

Anti-Federalists worried the presidency could become an elected monarchy — a fear that shaped term limits and impeachment (GC.16, connects to Unit 1 GC.04).

The Bureaucracy

Millions of federal employees in departments and agencies carry out the law day to day, raising questions about who really controls policy (GC.17).

The Electoral College

The winner of the most national votes has sometimes lost the presidency, sparking a lasting debate over how we choose a President (GC.18).

Unit Reflection

Return to the unit's big question: How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check? Write a final claim with two pieces of evidence from different standards.

Part	Write here
My claim	

Part	Write here
Evidence 1 (standard: __)	
Evidence 2 (standard: __)	
Why it matters today	